Giant Ancient Snake From India May Have Been Super Long

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About 47 million years ago, a giant snake lived in what is now western India. Scientists named it Vasuki indicus. It may have been one of the biggest snakes ever.

The discovery was described in 2024. Two scientists from the Indian Institute of Technology Roorkee studied 27 **fossil** bones from the snake's **backbone**. The bones were found at a mine in Gujarat, India.

The snake was named after Vasuki, a snake in Hindu stories that wraps around the neck of the god Shiva.

The scientists did not find the whole **skeleton**. They compared the bones with those of living snakes. They think Vasuki was about 36 to 50 feet long. That is close to Titanoboa, another giant ancient snake. But the scientists say they are not sure which snake was longer.

Vasuki had a thick, heavy body and probably moved slowly. It may have hidden and waited for **prey**, like **anacondas** do today. Back then, Earth was much warmer.

Word Treasure

fossil -- Remains of a plant or animal from long ago, kept in rock.

backbone -- The line of bones that runs down the middle of an animal's back.

skeleton -- All the bones of an animal's body together.

prey -- An animal that another animal hunts for food.

anacondas -- Very large snakes that live in South America today.

Background you need

Fossils are the remains of animals from long ago that turned into rock over time.

A snake's backbone has many small bones, so scientists can guess its size from just some of them.

Titanoboa is another giant snake from long ago that scientists often use to compare sizes.

Break it down

WHO: Two scientists from the Indian Institute of Technology Roorkee
WHAT: They studied fossils of Vasuki indicus, a giant ancient snake
WHERE: A mine in Gujarat, western India
WHY: The bones show it may have been one of the biggest snakes ever

Why it matters

Fossils let kids and scientists picture amazing animals that lived long before any people.

Test what you remember

1. What is the giant ancient snake called?

- (A) Titanoboa
- (B) Shiva
- (C) Gujarat
- (D) Vasuki indicus

2. About how long ago did the snake live?

- (A) Last summer
- (B) 47 years ago
- (C) 47 million years ago
- (D) 470 years ago

3. How many fossil bones did the scientists study?

- (A) Just one
- (B) 500
- (C) 2
- (D) 27

4. About how long do scientists think Vasuki was?

- (A) About 36 to 50 feet
- (B) About 5 feet
- (C) About 1 mile
- (D) About 2 inches

5. How did the snake probably hunt?

- (A) By hiding and waiting for prey
- (B) By running fast
- (C) By digging holes
- (D) By flying

6. Where were the bones found?

- (A) On a mountain in Canada
- (B) In a forest in Brazil
- (C) At a beach in Florida
- (D) At a mine in Gujarat, India

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: D 4: A 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):